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Digital Leisure

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Scribbling For All

How long can non-English-speaking Indians be forced to learn ridiculous key combinations to type using a regular keyboard?

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What would you do if you discovered that the keys on your new keyboard had Chinese-looking characters printed on them? Get a replacement, of course. Or, if you're curious to an unhealthy extent, you'd try and figure how to use it—but as a pastime, for a few minutes at most.

Think, for a moment, about the predicament of those to whom English characters might as well be Chinese. Think about our rural masses. They don't know English, and they're forced to learn the alphabet if they want to use a regular keyboard. If you were forced to learn Chinese, you'd be outraged... yes?

It's a little like malaria. We'd certainly have already had a vaccine if the disease were prevalent in Western countries! Similarly, if Indians were to have developed the keyboard, it would have been much more functional for Indian languages. But that's not the case, and there's not much we can do about it. Or is there?

Language Technicalities

The major reasons for the low IT penetration rate in India are accessibility, affordability, and usability. Computers and IT-Enabled Services are accessible and affordable for the urban populace. Even if they are made available to the rural population, the usability factor prevails, due to lack of awareness and knowledge. For now, think about the lack of support for Indian languages on input devices, which is a major impediment to the use of computers in rural and small-town India.

The primary reason behind this lack of support in terms of keyboards is the diversity of the character shapes of Indian alphabets. For instance, Hindi has 36 consonants and 12 vowels that can modify the consonants. The shapes of the consonants get modified when used with a vowel modifier: these can appear on the top, at the bottom, or to the right of the consonant to form a compound character.

Now, recognising each (complex) shape of the newly-formed compound character becomes difficult

